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Structure and authority in a Bedouin tribe

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The rajal khair, then, is a broker in social relationships, a manipulator of loyalties. As a member of the "status group," he can afford to spend time and money in courting his fellow tribesmen, and, as a result, can accrue prestige and loyalty. This role, like that of the 'aqila, is a secular one. The sanctions which it controls are as economical as those of the 'aqila's are political. In this sense, they are differentiated from the role of rajal saalih whose sanctions are sacred in nature.

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The traditional role which we define as that of the rajal saalih, "the holy man," was probably much more important in the past than it is today. In al-Qasr, there are only two rajal saalih who share in traditional power: the one is a resident of al-Qasr proper, and the other, a member of the prestigious Sanusi family, lives near Marsa Matruh.

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The rajal saalih of al-Qasr, i.e. the local "holy man," is assured of status because he is an ashraf, one who claims descent from the family of the Prophet. He is also a member of the elder age-set, and while he is not rich, he cannot be considered poor. Though the "holy man" al-Sanusi lives near Matruh, he participates in the authority structure of al-Qasr and is a member of the "status group." He is sometimes referred to as rajal saalih kabir, "a great holy man," by virtue of his Sanusi heritage.

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The relative unimportance of this role as compared to that of the rajal khair in conflict regulation is a function  266 of the Bedouin attitude, or lack of it, toward religion. Since the time of Muhammad, the Bedouins have been considered notoriously bad Muslims. Today, the Bedouins tend to joke about their lack of zeal, and often point out that "holy men" are not to be trusted.² This is seen in Sa'adi behavior toward the Marabtin tribes who are their vassals. Theoretically, the Marabtin who trace descent to the Prophet and might be considered "sacred Tribes" should be respected by the "secular" Sa'adi tribes. But the Sa'adi of al-Qasr tend to deride the Marabit. For instance, the "holy man" of al-Qasr, 'Amm Salih, is a Marabit and well-known for his ability to successfully mediate in conflict situations. But one informant, pointing out this gift which 'Amm Salih possesses, said: "Amm Salih is a good man, he is not a Marabit." But 'Amm Salih identifies himself as a "rajal saalih" and a "Marabit"; he sees no role conflict here.

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² Professor Abou-Zeid also notes this trait in his study of the Bedouin near Sallum, on the Libyan border (1966:248).

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